EXCLUSIVE Businessweek | The China Issue

‘It’s an Endless Cycle’: China’s Lost Generation

Spirited lads and spirited girls are an emerging class of poor young people who see little hope for advancement through hard work.



Illustration: Huanhuan Wang for Bloomberg Businessweek

By Bloomberg Businessweek
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On a breezy September evening in Shenyang, a city of 9.3 million people in China’s northeastern rust belt, 19-year-old Bai Yongguang is keeping still whil a tattoo artist goes to work. As the electric needle begins etching the red face of a Japanese *hannya* mask on his left forearm, the first part of a full-body piece that will include a Chinese dragon and a tiger, Bai is using his free hand to chain-smoke Lucky Strikes. To Bai, ink and tobacco are two nonnegotiable expenses. The stinging pain and hum of the needle ground him, and smoking

offers a brief escape from the precarity that awaits him beyond the walls of th shop.

Bai grew up in a small village two hours away by high-speed rail, where his mother raises cattle and his father drives trucks selling animal feed, dreaming of a simple life close to nature. After dropping out of high school (he says he couldn't take the full-time, military-style dorm life), he drifted through factor gigs in a series of Chinese manufacturing hubs until an overdose of cough medicine left him with permanent nerve damage. When he clenches his fists, his arms shake uncontrollably, ruling out any more heavy manual labor. At Mixue, a well-known bubble tea chain, he serves as many as 1,000 cups of ice tea per shift for 3,800 yuan ($569) a month. To stretch his paycheck, he eats a single meal each day. "When I run out of money, my girlfriend and I just shar one slice of bread," he says. "We just live for today. Who can predict tomorrow?"



Another client getting a tattoo at the shop where Bai got his. *Photographer: Gilles Sabrie for Bloomberg Businessweek*

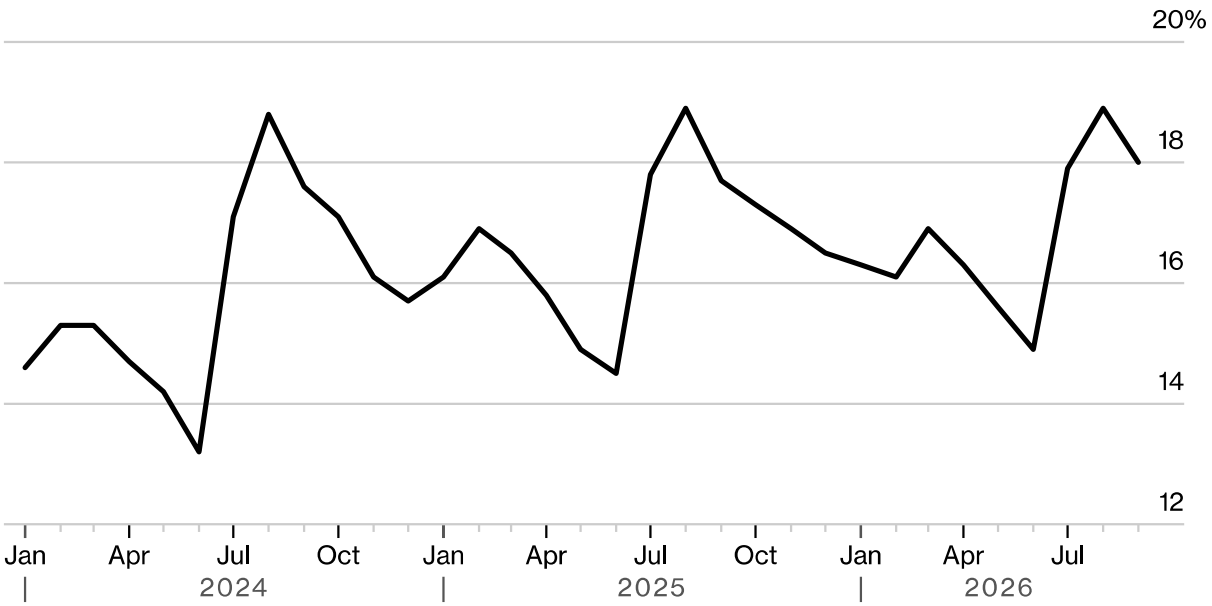
Bai is part of an emerging subculture in China called *jingshen xiaohuo* (精神小伙, spirited lads) and *jingshen xiaomei* (精神小妹, spirited girls), [1] who feel that the country's transformation into an economic superpower has left them

behind. These young men and women are struggling to pay their bills and see few paths for advancement as the economy cools, dragged down by a prolonged property downturn, sluggish household consumption and swelling local government debt. Their ranks include small-town dropouts, migrant youth on urban fringes and marginalized teens estranged from their parents. Many are living without steady work or are caught in cycles of substance abuse.

Although it's difficult to say how many people identify as spirited lads or girls the nationwide urban unemployment rate for 16- to 24-year-olds surged to a one-year high of 19% in August, and posts tagged "jingshen xiaohuo" have racked up 17 billion views on Kuaishou, a popular TikTok look-alike. These posts often feature tales of quiet desperation: spirited lads begging WeChat contacts for a little cash, sniffing hot-pot gas canisters, shoplifting unattended takeout meals.

A Lost Generation

Unemployment in China among urban youth age 16 to 24



Source: National Bureau of Statistics of China

In Shenyang, a faded industrial powerhouse that's still a regional magnet for some 1.6 million migrants, the spirited have come to favor certain aesthetics. Spirited lads have embraced full-body tattoos, golden-dyed bowl cuts with straight bangs, and skintight shirts and cropped trousers plastered with knockoff luxury logos. Spirited girls gravitate toward leg tattoos, heavy bangs exaggerated eyelashes and slip-on shoes. With relatively few opportunities fo

financial security through workaholism, some try to project a different kind c bravado. “I only go for guys with money,” spirited girl Xia Xinqi tells her 100,000 followers on Kuaishou in one viral clip. “If they’re broke, I won’t dat them.” But swagger can also fade quickly on streets like Shenyang’s. This is th view from what’s starting to look like China’s lost generation.



Spirited lads hanging out at a cafe. *Photographer: Gilles Sabrie for Bloomberg Businessweek*

Like America’s Midwestern Rust Belt, China’s industrial heartland has suffere from the downsides of deindustrialization for decades. Starting in the late 1990s, state enterprise reforms dismantled the region’s hidebound arms and infrastructure manufacturers and, with them, the government-run system of guaranteed housing, healthcare and lifetime employment known as the “iron rice bowl.” Mass layoffs followed, and the local safety net disintegrated. These days, Shenyang is home to a smattering of biomedical firms, a remarkably fancy luxury mall and the BMW Group’s largest global plant, but the city’s gross domestic product grew just 2% last year, well below the nationwide target of 5%. Here and there, aging apartment blocks have been halfway demolished. At busy intersections, many of Shenyang’s iconic bathhouses, symbols of local social culture, sit shuttered.

Taiyuan Street, the neighborhood where Bai is getting his latest tattoo, used t
be a bustling shopping district. Nowadays, its budget hostels, pool halls and e
sports lounges offer affordable sanctuaries for spirited lads who'd otherwise l
sleeping on the street. Across the three 31-story commercial buildings that
define the area, business is bad. Ma Panpan, who runs a hostel in one of the
towers, says things feel worse than they did during the Covid-19 lockdowns. M
is renting weekend rooms that once fetched 150 yuan for about 100 yuan, or
little as 40 yuan on weekdays after booking platforms such as Meituan take
their cut – meaning she's losing money on the deal. She's downsized from 10
rooms to 5 and is looking to get out of the business entirely.



Shenyang. *Photographer: Gilles Sabrie for Bloomberg Businessweek*

On a day that Ma ends with one room to spare, 17-year-old Wang Bairan
expects to end his night, per usual, at a 24-hour billiard parlor. Wang is the
tallest among a group of nine teens wandering aimlessly through an
underground shopping plaza on Taiyuan Street, periodically shouting, play-
shoving one another and drawing a fair bit of side-eye. He's wearing an all-
black outfit: baseball cap, hoodie and sweatpants, all emblazoned with what
appear to be knockoff Adidas logos. He says he's penniless, having recently
spent eight months in juvenile detention for fighting on the street, and hasn't
eaten in three days. His sole belongings are an iPhone X and a power bank.

Wang says his parents live in Tongliao in neighboring Inner Mongolia, rarely stay in touch and provide no financial support. He doesn't blame them. "If I had a son like this, I'd regret it completely," he says. "What a total waste of effort."

Of the nine spirited teens, Wang Sisi (no relation) is one of two girls in the group, and the only one who still has homework to worry about. She studies makeup at a vocational school, hoping it leads to work after graduation. She says that her boyfriend paid for her 1,000-yuan braces and that she scavenge her pink hoodie from a recycling station.

Americas

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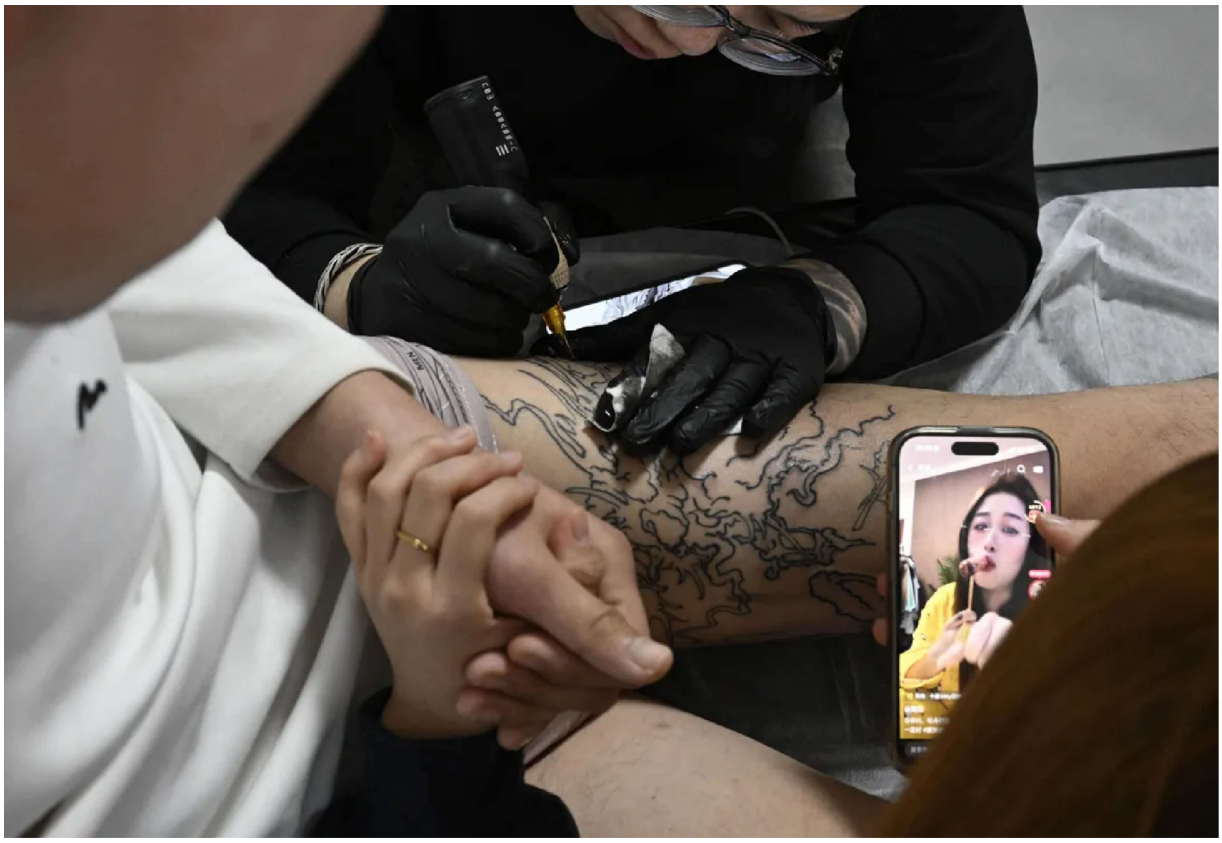
When his iPhone X is charged, Wang Bairan occasionally makes some money from viewers on Kuaishou, where he livestreams himself performing the signature spirited lad dances called "social shakes." And tiny measures of online fame can help spirited lads support themselves, for a while at least. Many with a knack for self-deprecating humor seek a boost from the cabaret scene that's long shaped the nightlife of Shenyang and its environs. At Super Red, an old-school disco hall a 20-minute drive from Taiyuan Street, an emce banters with the evening's entertainers, who range from balladeers to acrobats. Early in the evening, affluent older patrons sit at reserved tables tha come with a 500-yuan minimum. After 11 p.m., the atmosphere shifts as performers in tight outfits take the stage to dance to Western electronic musi



The scene at the tattoo shop. *Photographer: Gilles Sabrie for Bloomberg Businessweek*

Xiao Wen, 21, is among those waiting for the late-night crowd. He and six oth spirited lads strip off their T-shirts, revealing full-body tattoos, and pack onto narrow runway between tables to do some social shakes of their own, hoping to go viral on Kuaishou. Before the music had changed, Xiao didn't have the cash to book a table, so he loitered near the restrooms. He has no steady job and says he burns through whatever cash lands in his pocket from Kuaishou stunts, selling vape cartridges laced with veterinary anesthetics or extorting people on Blued, a gay dating app. On Blued, he says, he uses fake profiles to meet up with other men, then flashes a fake underage ID and threatens to cal the police. Usually, he says, this scam nets him 1,000 yuan to 2,000 yuan.

"It's an endless cycle between feeling flush and being totally broke," Xiao say "Once you're in it, trying to get out and settle down is pretty hard."



Tattoo artist Li Jinyang at work. *Photographer: Gilles Sabrie for Bloomberg Businessweek*

China has yet to see mass layoffs driven by artificial intelligence, and its enormous gig economy can help cushion job-hunters for a time. (Most notabl there's DiDi's ride-hailing network and Meituan's delivery service.) But for China's working poor more broadly, long-term prospects seem dim. The upward mobility promised by the country's top colleges is waning along with the job postings, and the idea of breaking through simply by working harder has grown less persuasive. In lieu of a 72-hour workweek, many young Chine are choosing, as one popular meme puts it, "lying flat" – opting out of the endless grind. Wary of what this might mean for population growth and the economy, several Chinese provinces are offering vouchers for newlyweds anc cash payouts for new parents.

Li Jinyang, the tattoo artist inking Bai's forearm, says he's proof that being a spirited lad isn't a life sentence. After dropping out of high school, he moved Shenyang with a single suitcase and wound up sleeping in a park storage shec One morning at 4 a.m., as the first patrons of the day arrived at a nearby market, he and two friends staggered out of the shed, pretending to be drunk to hide their homelessness. "Spirited lads care deeply about saving face," Li says. "That was the most humiliating moment of my life." Now, at the advanced age of 21, he's still spending a great deal of his time with spirited

lads, but they're his customers. He's stopped bleaching his hair and says it's been a while since his last street fight.



Li in his shop. *Photographer: Gilles Sabrie for Bloomberg Businessweek*

To accommodate cash-strapped clients, Li charges a flexible daily rate of 400 yuan for seven hours of work, letting customers complete pieces step by step as their funds allow. He says his best-selling tattoos are the intimidating kind: *hannya* masks, Chinese dragons, gods of war. He tries to talk young couples out of inking each other's names, but many ignore him. Bai did much the sam at a different shop, having the last Chinese character of his girlfriend's name, Han, tattooed near his heart. "I want to give her a sense of security," he says. "She's suffered too much with me."

For Bai, the job at Mixue marks a step toward a measure of stability. His parents recently visited him and his girlfriend in Shenyang, where their one-bedroom apartment costs 1,400 yuan a month, making it tough for them to save money. Reassured by his steady work, his mom and dad bought him an e bike, remembering how he used to love riding a dirt bike across his hometow desert, cruising for hours with nothing in sight. As Bai rides through city streets, his nerve-damaged hands trembling on the handlebars, he can appreciate the luxury. But the new bike doesn't spark the same sense of

freedom, or any particularly warm feelings about the future. –*Charlie Zhu and Zheping Huang*



9:24

Watch: Why Are China's Youth Boycotting Pensions?

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1. This aesthetic signals working poor in China who are "lying flat" — giving up on the idea that the can make a better living so long as they work from 9 a.m. to 9 p.m., six days a week View in arti

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